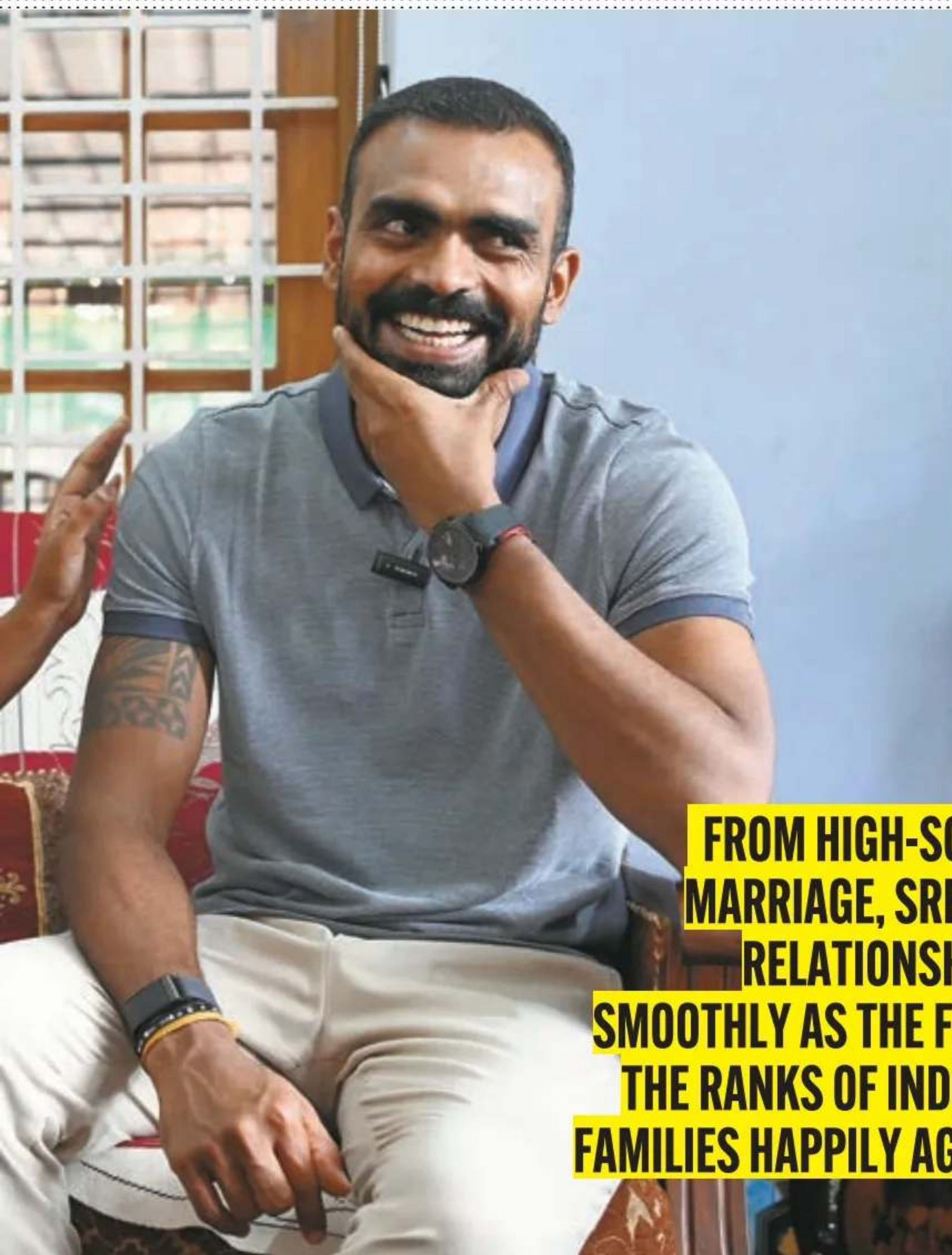




FROM HIGH-SCHOOL SWEETHEARTS TO MARRIAGE, SREEJESH AND ANEESHYA'S RELATIONSHIP HAS PROGRESSED AS SMOOTHLY AS THE FORMER'S RISE THROUGH THE RANKS OF INDIAN HOCKEY, WITH BOTH FAMILIES HAPPILY AGREEING TO THEIR UNION

medals, if even one feels a strong desire, that's all we need. **We won't be able to change an entire generation, but if we can inspire one person out of 100, that's job done,**" Sreejesh remarked with quiet pride. He also broke from tradition when he quickly labelled the Tokyo bronze as his favourite.

"The first medal, for sure, is my favourite. The taste of food for a hungry person is vastly different from that of someone who's already eaten. That first medal was like rain on drought-hit land. The celebrations, reliving each moment — it was all for that medal.

This time, we went expecting to

win. Last time, we didn't have that expectation; we just hoped for the best," Sreejesh explained.

Meanwhile, his wife Aneeshya, an Ayurveda doctor, joined us with cups of sweet tea and a side of jokes, adding a casual, light-hearted tone to the interview.

The two met at GV Raja Sports School, where she was an aspiring long jumper and Sreejesh was just learning the basics of hockey.

"I was worried about him getting hurt in the beginning, but then I realised he had it under control. He was always so calm heading to the field," Aneeshya recalled, as their children — 10-year-old Anusree and

seven-year-old Sreeansh — darted shyly through the living room, avoiding the cameras. From high-school sweethearts to marriage, their relationship progressed as smoothly as Sreejesh's rise through the ranks of Indian hockey, with both families happily agreeing to their union.

"There were no issues. Where else could they find a guy like me?" joked Sreejesh, teasing his wife.

The couple has found their own rhythm when it comes to raising their children, especially given Sreejesh's demanding career, which often takes him away for long stretches.

"Parenting is about raising your kids right. My wife and parents were there physically while I worked to secure their future. I feel that's better than being with them all the time but

not being able to provide for them financially.

"I'm always a star in their eyes, and that's what matters. Of course, they may have missed me when I was away, but I think they enjoy my success and stardom more," Sreejesh added. For all his daredevilry on the hockey field, Sreejesh prefers to play it safe off it.

A prized possession of his younger days, a yellow Pulsar 180, rarely ventures out of the garage, held back by Sreejesh's fear of potential injury.

Like many of his Malayali peers, he subscribes to the middle-class holy trinity of investments: fixed deposits, land, and gold. His wife, Aneeshya, proudly notes that "money